Breath, Boom

By Kia Corthron

Cutting focuses on Cat who is in juvenile detention for running away from her foster home and possibly prostitution at age 15 – In this cutting she speaks to Prix, her cell mate. (Jail cell – bunk cots)

CAT: *(To Prix)* My name is Cat. I'm coming to your group tomorrow. I told Miss Collins I didn't feel comfortable in my group, she said Give it a try, you only been here a month, I said Some of them bitches threatenin' me, say they gonna take my teeth out. Randy, Scooter. She said I'll talk to 'em. I said I wish you wouldn't That really make life hell, I wish you just change my group please. The lie is, Randy and Scooter never said nothin' 'bout my teeth, I just hate their ugly faces wanted get away from 'em. The truth is, Miss Collins tell 'em what I said I *would* be in life-threatenin' trouble for lyin' 'bout 'em the first place. Luckily Miss Collins buy it I'm your group tomorrow. *(Beat)* Lap a luxury. Three meals. Street clothes.

PRIX: You the only one around here ready to print up the welcome travelers' brochure for jail.

CAT: I hear 'em! Cryin' on the phone, "My honey, my honey," Most of 'em honeys was kickin' the shit out of 'em daily and their *friends*? Their best girlfriend's on the outside and so's their honey guess what one plus one is equalin'? *(Beat.)* Could be worse. See them ugly green one-piece things they make the women wear? Least adolescents, we wear our own shit. *(Beat.)* Easy time. Eleven <months> left for me, shit. Scotfree and I'm fifteen, three more years a minor, I get caught, easy time. Eleven months. I *know* my roof? *Know* my mealtimes? shit. Damn sure beats the fosters.

PRIX: Usually all I hear's you whinin' 'bout the clothes situation.

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CAT: Lacka choices! I love my clothes, but wearin' the same five outfits gets limitin' after awhile. Ain't my first time in. Fourth!

PRIX: Runaway.

CAT: Three more years I'm a criminal for it! Can't wait 'til eighteen! Runnin' away *(Beat)* Dontcha never believe that crap about best to tell the counselor tell the teacher it'll make things better. Cuz ya *will* get sent back home and just when ya thought things could get no worse, they do.

INTRODUCTION

It's a fundamental desire to want to fit in, to feel accepted -- to feel loved. But what happens when our peers cast us off? For Cat, being an outcast has been a way of life. Though she is desperate to fit in -- even in juvenile detention -- there is no group she can fit into because deep down she believes "the big lie" that she is not worthy to be a part of any group. BREATH, BOOM by Kia Corthron.

CAT: *(to her cellmate, Prix)* What's the big one? Single most thing earned you all the gracious undivided esteem? I heard this: shot a enemy girl in the face. Then went to her funeral cuz yaw was best friends second grade, put the whole goddamn family on edge and every one of 'em knew and not one of them said a word about it to you. *(Beat.)* And one time jumpin a girl in, and she not too conscious, but you jump your whole weight on her face ten times maybe? Twelve? 'Fore a sister pull you off. And one time on a revenge spree, dress up like a man so no one identify you later, stick your hair under a cap and shoot dead some boy teen years old. *And . . .*

PRIX: Fifteen *(pause: Cat is confused)* I don't kill no kids. Fifteen.

CAT: O.G.! you gonna earn it. Original Gangsta, people respect you long after you retire. Take me in! (no answer) You get it. The high, right? The kickin' and smashin' and breakin' bones snap! Somebody lyin' still in a flood a their own blood. *You* made it happen! Them dead, *you* done it! You ever get that high?

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(Thinking silently about wanting to be in a gang.) Take me in! I tried once, Small little club I was interested in. Wore the right colors, I talked the shit. They wouldn't even jump me in, I said "I'll do it! Either way, all yaw stand in a line and rough me through it OR I'll take the toughest one on, two minutes!" They just laugh. *(Beat.)*

PRIX: Wannabe

CAT: They think I ain't tough I got it! I can fight! I was four, these two boys was six, tried to steal my bike I flattened 'em! And when my foster sisters steak-knife stabbed me and drowned me in the tub, somebody called an ambulance, he mouth-to-mouthed me back alive, said if I wasn't strong I'da stayed dead. *(Chuckles.)* She's dead! Jessie, she the one screamin' "Hold her down! No air bubbles hold the bitch 'til she dead dead dead!" Look who's talkin', she with her homegirls and boys thinkin' she a member in good standin', got drunk one night and said somethin' smart to a homey, he blew her head off. *(Laughs.)*

PRIX: You ever wish you done it? You ever . . . You ever regret wasn't you pulled that trigger?

CAT: *(Confused)* She's dead.

PRIX: Yeah, but like . . . that thought. It ever get stuck your mind? Wishin' the last thing she seen was you robbin' her last breath?

CAT: *(Beat – changes subject as she refocuses on her clothes)* The clothes make me mad. How come only five outfits? *(Beat)*

PRIX: What makes me mad is music. John Philip Souza, trombone pansy crap. <But> fireworks got their own music: reports and hummers, whistles. Magic, each one born with that little sound. A gulp. A breath. And we holdin' our breaths, waitin' three . . . four . . . five . . . .BOOM! Then nothin' left but pastel smoke, pink, blue floatin' calm. Calm.

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CAT: *(Admiration)* You the coldest fish I know! Ruthless! *(Beat)* You met Ms. Bramer? She's the new Current Events -- she's nice I hope she stick around awhile. She say the six ' o'clock news always hypin:' "Tough on teens! Youth violence outa hand, try 'em like adults!" But she say news never say three times as many murders committed by late-forties as by age under-eighteens. Ms. Bramer say if we violent where we learn it? Sow what you reap.

PRIX: Reap what you sow. *(Long pause as CAT thinks)*

CAT: *(Suddenly sobbing):* They took 'em away! They took em' away! . . . . Little boy! Had a baby! Little boy, they make me, they made me adopt him away! They said Do it! They said Do it! *(long pause while Cat composes herself)* [It was] before I was charged! I oughtn't be here no way, awaitin' trail, innocent 'til proven guilty, how come I gotta sit here for lacka five hundred? They ain't proved nothin' yet. *(As Cat speaks she will pull the sheet off the upper bunk, then sit tying it.)* You ever plan your funeral?

PRIX: Fireworks.

CAT: Knew it! Nothin' somber for me neither, I got the tunes all picked out, went through my CD collection, I know who my special guest stars be, I figure they come, like this poor unfortunate fifteen-year-old girl died, aint the city violent and sad? <The celebrities> feel so depressed [they] come give a free funeral concert. *(Beat)* My coffin's gonna be open. I'm gonna look good *(Drift into daydreaming)* I got the dress picked, and I want people to see it. You ever plan your suicide?

PRIX: Fifth grade

CAT: Pills? Gun stuck up your mouth?

PRIX: Off the Brooklyn Bridge. *(puzzled)* Would that kill ya?

CAT: <Know where I was yesterday?> Infirmary, doctor checkin' me out after this girl come up to me *pow!* She say, "What your name?" I'm tryin' to answer, "My name's Cat" but before I get the first word out *pow!* She punch me in my face I'm all

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knocked out! Supper tonight, I seen her people, them girls follows her around, she weren't there guess they threw her in the bean. I come to her girls, say, "Your friend ask me what my name is. My name's Cat." But soon as I say "Your friend ask me what my name is" they start laughin' so hard I think they don't hear the second part, so I keep sayin' it louder but the louder I say it the louder they laugh. "My name is Cat!" *(Beat, stands on the upper bunk.)* "MY NAME IS CAT!" *(Cat has swung the sheet --- tied into a rope—around an overhead horizontal pope and secured it. It is suddenly clear that she has formed a noose. Standing on the edge of the bunk, she has stuck her head through it. If she jumps off, she'll hang. Her eyes are closed, her breathing harsh and uneven. The most delicate push would be enough to knock her over.)*

PRIX: Jump!

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AWARD HISTORY

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